Chinese carmakers are coming for Europe's luxury market

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【要点】

・EUはブリュッセルで中国のハイブリッド車流入を抑制する予備合意を結んだが、中国メーカーはすでに欧州の高級車市場への進出準備を進めており対策が追いついていない。

・XPengの旗艦SUV「G9L」やLeapmotorなど中国メーカーは、高級セグメントで高い競争力を持つ電動車を展開し、ドイツの有名メーカーを脅かしている。

・中国メーカーはオーストリアなどEU域内での生産拠点設立や欧州企業とのパートナーシップにより、関税回避と販売網確保を実現している。

・Leapmotorはステランティスとの合弁により急速に販売を伸ばし、イタリアではフィアット500eを上回る販売実績を達成している。

【メール原文】

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Chinese carmakers are coming for Europe's luxury market
By Jordyn Dahl · Oct 13, 2026, 6:00 AM · View in your browser

PARIS — Brussels struck a preliminary deal with Beijing to curb the flood of Chinese hybrid cars into the EU. It may be too late.

Chinese automakers made clear at the Paris Auto Show that they're already preparing for their next offensive: conquering Europe's luxury car market.

From high-end hybrid SUVs to all-electric roadsters, Chinese manufacturers unveiled ambitious expansion plans that threaten to challenge a segment long dominated by German automakers Mercedes-Benz, BMW and Porsche.

The contrast underscores a growing dilemma for Brussels: Its efforts to contain Chinese competition are struggling to keep pace with automakers moving into new market segments, setting up European factories and forging partnerships with the very EU companies they're threatening to displace and that Brussels is trying to protect.

Take XPeng's G9L, the Chinese firm's flagship luxury SUV for Europe, which debuted at the show when it opened on Monday. The electric vehicle comes with road-noise cancellation and a built-in refrigerator and goes on sale in France in December for €75,000. That's still less than BMW's electric iX1 , priced at roughly €88,000.

XPeng is producing the car in China and in Graz, Austria, with automotive contract manufacturer Magna. Manufacturing it in the EU means XPeng won't have to pay the extra duties the European Commission imposed on made-in-China electric vehicles in 2024.

Other Chinese automakers are partnering with European counterparts to gain access to distribution networks. That strategy has paid off for Leapmotor, which set up a joint venture with Stellantis in 2023.

The Chinese brand saw its sales surge, particularly in Italy, where customers could receive a subsidy of up to €11,000 per electric vehicle. Leapmotor's T03 — a small, city-focused model — is Italy's top-selling EV, with over 23,000 sold in the first nine months of this year, according to market data . Stellantis' small EV, the Fiat 500e, sold just 1,272 over the same period.

Stellantis CEO Antonio Filosa dismissed concerns that the partnership risks cannibalizing the European automaker's sales, arguing the deal keeps the brand from shuttering factories.

"Our solution is instead of closing plants, we want to share that excess capacity with good partners that we can select, and we can grow together with," he said at a press briefing Monday. The partnerships, he added, "work both ways," with Leapmotor sharing technology in return.

Filosa said EU policymakers could also help the struggling sector by passing the Industrial Accelerator Act, which would set "Made in Europe" content requirements for strategic sectors in public procurement and support schemes, and giving automakers more flexibility in meeting emissions targets, which they must hit or face fines.

He isn't making that push alone. Volkswagen's message at the Paris Auto Show was "For Europe," a reference to the IAA. VW and Stellantis were the first automakers to back the proposal in June, shortly after it was proposed .

But the German and French governments have been at loggerheads over the legislation. Paris wants a limited number of third countries to qualify as "Made in Europe," while Berlin worries about angering EU trade partners that might be excluded.

The two countries are negotiating a trade-off : Berlin will give ground on the Industrial Accelerator Act in exchange for Paris backing more flexibility in the industry's CO_2 emissions targets.

French President Emmanuel Macron, who attended the Paris show on Monday, said "a deal is imminent," adding "it is a matter of hours or days."

An earlier joint stance by Germany and France on China helped pave the way for the Commission's deal with Beijing to limit the latter's booming hybrid car exports. Berlin had staunchly opposed duties on China-made electric vehicles, but a slew of layoffs and factory closures in Germany have pushed the chancellery toward tackling the trade imbalance head on.

Stellantis and Volkswagen welcomed the Brussels-Beijing deal on hybrid vehicles.

"We welcome the recent progress in EU-China trade talks. But Europe must still ensure a level playing field in its own markets," Volkswagen's CEO Oliver Blume told journalists at an event on Sunday.

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